PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Mercedes-Benz G-Class W460

1979–1991 · W460 · 230 GE · 280 GE · 300 GD

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust first, everything else second**
  Classic & Sports Car says rust starts in the rear body corners. Check the inner wings, the bottom of the rear door and the shock top mounts visible in the wheel arch. Auto Bild adds the sills, the area under the windscreen, the spring mounts and the fuel tank. Most W460s lived in salty European winters, so a rot-free one costs more for good reason.
- [ ] **Work the front-axle lever and the lockers**
  Engage 4WD and low range, then lock the rear and front diffs on a loose surface and listen for clean engagement. On a W460 the locks are hydraulic and can take a few wheel turns to bite. A lock that never engages usually points to a tired master cylinder, slave cylinders or flex lines.
- [ ] **Overheating history**
  Classic & Sports Car warns that overheating and cylinder-head warping are common, and that an old radiator is probably clogged. Check the coolant for oil, look for weeps, and budget for a new radiator if the original is still fitted.
- [ ] **Steering box and springs**
  Look for oil leaking from the bottom of the steering box, broken coil springs, leaking dampers and signs of hard off-road abuse. Excess play at the wheel usually means box, tie-rod or drag-link wear.
- [ ] **Water where it shouldn't be**
  Classic & Sports Car flags leaks from the wiper spindles, sunroof and heater plenum, and the rear-door hinge seals perish with age. Lift the mats and look for stains and soft metal under them.
- [ ] **Originality and paperwork**
  Hagerty, quoting Club G-Wagen co-founder Mike Serpe, says buyers pay up to 30% more for an all-original G and that any grey-market truck needs an expert inspection. Mercedes-Benz Classic sells factory data cards for most cars built from 1986, so a late W460's original spec can be checked; ask the seller for it.
- [ ] **Know what you're buying into**
  A 300 GD makes 88 PS and tops out around 127 km/h (79 mph). An IH8MUD owner says even his truck, swapped to a mildly built OM617 turbodiesel, ran out of steam at about 70 mph. If you need it to keep up on the interstate, buy a different G.

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Chassis number**
  Chassis numbers on Bring a Trailer-sold W460s start with the 460 model code: a 1986 300 GD is WDB460333..., a 1984 230 GE Cabriolet WDB460218.... Earlier trucks often show the number without the WDB prefix (e.g. 460333...).
- [ ] **Lockers**
  Mercedes made front and rear diff locks standard on every W460 from 1985, so earlier trucks may not have them. Look for the locker control on the dash and the slave cylinders on the axles. A W460 never has a centre lock.
- [ ] **Part-time 4WD**
  The front axle is engaged by lever through the transfer case, with high and low range. Permanent 4WD means you're looking at a W463 or a W461 with W463 running gear.
- [ ] **Engine swaps**
  Turbodiesel OM603/OM606 and even GM V8 swaps turn up regularly on Bring a Trailer. BaT has sold OM606-powered 300 GDs for $69,696 and $79,500. Check the engine number against the model badge and know what you're paying for.
- [ ] **Puch badging**
  In Austria and some other markets the G was sold as a Puch. A Puch-badged truck is still a G, just with a different badge (and on Puch W461s, a VAG chassis prefix).

NOTES

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